

GEOORGIA

ENTERTAINMENT





LIVE

Illustration by
Delaney Williams

HONOR BOWMAN HALL - EXECUTIVE DEAN

ANDREA JOHNSON - ASSOCIATE DEAN

MAKUMBI MULEBA - ASSISTANT DIRECTOR

LEANNE ROBINSON-MAINE - SCADAMP

Zion-Alexander

Staff Writer

For Shirley Zhang-Hamlin, vice president of creative for the Atlanta Hawks, design isn't just about visuals; it's about heart. "It is about taking a moment to capture the players' personalities as people," she says. "It's about inviting fans to share in that excitement and shining a spotlight on what makes each of them unique."

Passionate, driven and something of a self-described "free bird," Zhang-Hamlin carries the weighty but exhilarating responsibility of shaping how the Hawks are seen around the world. From sponsor collaborations and marketing campaigns to arena graphics and community events, every element that touches the public eye passes through her creative lens. "It's not a nine-to-five job," she admits. "You're on everybody else's time but your own."

DESIGNING BELONGING:

SHIRLEY ZHANG-HAMLIN AND THE HEART OF THE HAWKS

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“

The great qualities of a designer are to think beyond yourself, to think beyond your bubble.”

With more than 60 sponsors to coordinate, nonstop media announcements and the ever-present drive to fill seats and fuel fan enthusiasm, her world moves fast. Yet she speaks of it with gratitude and a smile. “When you see how all these details work together to create lasting memories for the fans, that’s the reward.”

That joy in connecting design to emotion began early. As a child, Zhang-Hamlin was endlessly curious, “trouble,” she jokes, for never accepting things as they were. “I was always uncovering the whys and trying to improve the design,” she recalls. That creative restlessness would eventually lead her to the Savannah College of Art and Design, where she found both discipline and community. “The great qualities of a designer are to think beyond yourself, to think beyond your bubble,” she says. Her education, surrounded by a globally diverse student body, taught her to see design through a wider cultural lens, one that continues to inform her work today.

Before stepping into the sports world, Zhang-Hamlin built a strong design career with major retail brands like OshKosh B’Gosh and Carter’s, where her reliability and leadership earned respect and recognition. A former colleague later recommended her for an opening with the Atlanta Hawks, a suggestion she initially laughed off. “I never dreamt of working for sports or entertainment,” she says. “It just wasn’t in my peripheral.”

Still, when the opportunity arose, she took a leap of faith. “It’s easy to feel underqualified,” she says. “But there’s

nothing I’m afraid of that I can’t learn. What I do know is that it’s better to have the opportunity than to never have the opportunity.” That mindset, the willingness to bet on herself, carried her into a role where her creativity could truly take flight.

Her favorite day of the year is media day, when the Hawks gather for an intensive one-day shoot that generates all the images and video used across the season’s campaigns. “It’s my favorite because it’s a chance to capture the players’ personalities,” she says. “To make content they can be proud of, because it really represents who they are.”

Zhang-Hamlin’s work underscores the balance between entertainment and authenticity. “As a brand, you can either love a team because they’re winning, or you can love the team because you fell in love with these people and what the brand is about.” For her, the true magic of sports design lies in building that second kind of love, one rooted in human connection.

Despite her title and success, she remains grounded. “I just want to be a good human and be additive to the world and to the people that engage with me,” she says. “That is the most valuable thing.”

For someone who once couldn’t sit still in the face of “how things are,” Shirley Zhang-Hamlin has found her place shaping how the world sees one of the NBA’s most dynamic teams, and in doing so, she’s designed something far greater than a brand. She’s designed belonging.



Images by
Alexa Carmona



THE SOUTH'S GOT SOMETHING TO SAY:

ATLANTA AND GEORGIA LEADING THE CREATIVE REVOLUTION

Mayor Andre Dickens

City of Atlanta

Picture this: It's the summer of 2026, and the exhilarating roar of the crowd at Mercedes-Benz Stadium reverberates across Atlanta and the entire state of Georgia as FIFA World Cup matches set the city ablaze with infectious energy and excitement.

It's a moment we will always remember, and moments like these have shaped Georgia and Atlanta's cultural identities for decades.

I grew up here in Atlanta, a city that has always set the stage. From Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.'s powerful voice echoing across the world and changing the course of history to Andre 3,000 of the iconic hip-hop duo Outkast declaring "the South's got something to say," Atlanta has never been quiet. That energy lives in our arenas, studios, film sets and neighborhoods, and it keeps finding new ways to resonate on a global scale.

Images by
Alexa Carmona

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The coming years will put Atlanta and the entire state of Georgia directly in the spotlight like never before. FIFA World Cup matches will electrify audiences. The Super Bowl returns in 2028. Our incredible teams at Hartsfield-Jackson Atlanta International Airport, the world's busiest and most efficient airport, will welcome visitors from every continent. These milestones showcase how sports and entertainment connect with innovation, storytelling and technology.

Georgia's entertainment economy, anchored by the Georgia Entertainment Industry Investment Act, thrives on a vibrant and diverse creative community. Homegrown productions from "Black Panther" to "Stranger Things" have shaped popular culture at every level. Atlanta proudly stands as the epicenter of Georgia's creative industry, a dynamic hub where entrepreneurs, artists, hairdressers, hospitality workers, production assistants, visionary writers, digital media specialists, musicians and coders push the boundaries of music, gaming, esports and digital media.

Like many creative hubs, our entertainment industry has faced its fair share of challenges amid industry strikes, shifting market dynamics and growing global competition. Yet, Atlanta's emergence as a technology leader is changing how we approach these challenges. With rapid growth in AI, fintech, data centers and other cutting-edge sectors, the city blends creativity with technological innovation.

Atlanta also offers quality-of-place advantages that attract creative professionals. Housing affordability and inclusive policies make our city a welcoming environment, while expansive transit options improve connectivity across Atlanta and its neighborhoods. This unique synergy of livability and innovation strengthens our resilience and positions us to pioneer

new ways of producing, distributing and experiencing entertainment. The energy from our growing tech ecosystem ensures that Atlanta and Georgia will continue to lead the creative revolution with vision and adaptability.

Metro Atlanta's state-of-the-art sound stages such as Trilith Studios, Tyler Perry Studios, Cinespace, Assembly Atlanta and more, anchor this creative ecosystem and fuel Georgia's reputation as a global production center. Iconic venues like the Fox Theatre, Tabernacle and State Farm Arena maintain vibrant cultural life year-round, hosting concerts, premieres, esports tournaments and award shows. Renowned educational institutions, including Spelman, Morehouse, SCAD, Georgia State and my alma mater, Georgia Tech, nurture ongoing talent pipelines prepared for industries that continue to evolve and thrive here.

Innovation continues to push new frontiers. We've launched esports labs and creative suites at various city recreation centers, offering young talent the chance to compete globally. University programs are blending film, design and computing in curricula designed for careers unimaginable a decade ago. Atlanta's musical influence spans alternative, hip hop, R&B, gospel, rock and beyond, reaching global audiences. Projects like the Atlanta Beltline and Centennial Yards transform the city's heart, fusing culture, technology and community into immersive experiences like none our nation has ever seen.

Georgia shows how to embrace change with creativity and strength. As we prepare to host FIFA, industry professionals across film, live entertainment, digital media, hospitality and tech collaborate to create extraordinary experiences that will resonate long after the final whistle.

Partnership drives this progress. My

administration and our teams including the Mayor's Office of Film, Entertainment and Nightlife; Invest Atlanta; Showcase Atlanta; the Atlanta World Cup Host Committee; the Atlanta Convention & Visitors Bureau; the Atlanta Sports Council; our law enforcement partners; the Department of Transportation; and the Mayor's Office of Cultural Affairs, and more, all work closely with Georgia state departments, private companies, nonprofits and community groups.

Together, we cultivate innovative public and private partnerships that craft unforgettable sports and entertainment events, leaving lasting legacies our citizens and visitors will never forget. This united effort has brought landmark events like the 1996 Summer Olympic Games, the Super Bowl, NCAA Final Four, the College Football Playoff and the MLB All-Star Game to life right here in our backyard, proving that there's a reason they say Atlanta influences everything.

Atlanta is a diverse and inclusive city, where a wide range of voices and talents come together, reflected in every facet of our creative economy and the experiences we share with visitors across the state. As Mayor, I am proud of the progress we've made to build a city and state that works for everyone, a place where opportunity, equity and innovation come together to create a brighter future.

As I often say, Atlanta is a group project, and so is the entire state of Georgia. This is no more evident than in our creative industries. It's the collaboration, shared vision and collective passion that set the tone for growth and innovation here.

Now, Atlanta and Georgia's voice echoes more powerfully than ever. The South's got something to say, and this time, the world is listening.



Grammy-winning producer Dallas Austin is pictured with the Mayor.

Joshua Spruiel/Photographer, Mayor's Office of Communications



STORYTELLING:

DELTA'S STRATEGY FOR BUILDING GENUINE CONNECTIONS

Jennifer Reynolds

Managing Editor

In an era when consumers can skip ads, mute commercials and scroll past sponsored posts in seconds, major brands are getting creative about how they capture attention and build loyalty. Rather than simply talking at their audiences, companies like Delta Air Lines are investing in authentic content that entertains, educates and engages, turning marketing budgets into experiences that customers actually seek out.

Delta's approach exemplifies this shift. Through initiatives like its YouTube channel, the airline has moved beyond traditional advertising to create content that resonates with travelers on a deeper level. It's a strategy that requires patience, creativity and a willingness to meet customers where they already are, not just with a sales pitch but with stories worth watching.

But what drives a major corporation to invest in these creative outlets? How do brands measure success when the

goal isn't just clicks or conversions but a genuine connection? And in a crowded digital landscape, what does it take to cut through the noise and build a brand that people don't just recognize but actually care about?

We sat down with Alicia Tillman, chief marketing officer for Delta Air Lines, to explore how creativity has become central to the company's brand-building strategy, why these investments pay off and what other major brands can learn from taking creative risks.



Image courtesy of Delta

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Investing in Creativity: How Fulton County Fuels the Arts.

Building Fulton's Future Through the Arts

Fulton County Arts & Culture (FCAC) is committed to making the arts accessible, engaging, and impactful for every resident. Through its Contracts for Services (CFS) program, the County invests in local artists, nonprofit organizations, and cultural institutions whose work enriches the community and strengthens Fulton's cultural identity.

Each year, the CFS program provides funding to support a wide range of projects from visual art exhibitions and theater productions to music performances, festivals, educational workshops, and community-based initiatives. These contracts not only help sustain the creative economy but also ensure that Fulton County remains a thriving hub for cultural expression.

The goal is simple yet powerful: to expand access to the arts, support diverse voices, and provide meaningful cultural experiences that inspire, educate, and connect residents. By doing so, Fulton County demonstrates its commitment to building stronger communities and nurturing the next generation of artists and audiences.

Our mission is to make art accessible to all of the residents of Fulton County.



David Manuel,
Director Fulton County
Arts & Culture



Through Contracts for Services, the County affirms that the arts are not a luxury, they are an essential part of everyday life.

Fulton County Arts & Culture

What It Is:

A funding program that invests in artists, nonprofits, and cultural organizations.

Why It Matters:

Expands access to the arts, strengthens communities, and celebrates diversity.

Who Benefits:

Fulton County residents of all ages through performances, exhibitions, festivals, workshops, and more.

The Impact:

Supporting the creative economy while ensuring art remains an essential part of everyday life.

Contracts for Services:

Supporting Artists.
Strengthening Communities.

Q: Delta has a reputation for innovation in how it engages with customers. From your perspective, why is creativity such an important part of building and sustaining that connection?

Tillman: What makes creativity so powerful is its ability to transform routine interactions into memorable moments. It's how we evolve from being just an airline to becoming a lifestyle brand.

Creativity allows us to meet those expectations in ways that are both innovative and deeply personal. Whether it's through our social media or e-commerce platforms, our partnerships or the design of our lounges, experiential events and on board experiences, we use creativity to tell a story that reflects our customers' lifestyles and aspirations.

From initiatives like our SkyMiles Member Lounge at the PGA Tour Championship to integrating free Wi-Fi, curated content and our new YouTube partnership, we're constantly exploring new ways to engage with our customers beyond the flight. Creativity helps us stay ahead of trends, connect with emerging generations like Gen Z and build loyalty

through experiences that feel authentic and relevant.

Ultimately, creativity is how we bring our brand purpose to life by designing every touchpoint to reflect care, innovation and a deep understanding of what our customers value most.

Q: The recent YouTube partnership is a great example of meeting audiences where they already spend time. What was the inspiration behind that initiative, and how do you see it enhancing the in-flight experience?

Tillman: Delta and YouTube are two brand powerhouses, both leaders in our respective spaces. Together, we're uniquely positioned to create an unmatched customer experience through innovation and scale. The partnership was born from a simple but powerful insight: our customers love YouTube. It's the No. 1 website SkyMiles Members visit when connected to Delta Sync Wi-Fi, so bringing it on board as our newest Delta Sync partner was a natural next step. It's important to us that we meet customers where they already are

and elevate their journey with content and experiences that feel highly relevant, curated for them and aligned with how they want to engage both in the air and on the ground.

Q: Beyond partnerships, Delta also develops original content like the Power Forward series. How do you decide which stories or formats best align with your brand values and resonate with customers?

Tillman: At Delta, we believe stories are the most powerful way to connect with people. With the Power Forward series, we didn't just want to highlight athletic achievements—we wanted to show the human journey behind each player. We chose athletes Cameron Brink, Nneka Ogwumike and Breanna Stewart because they represent different stages of leadership and growth in the WNBA. Their stories of grit, vulnerability and triumph mirror the values we hold as a brand. When content reflects real lives and shared aspirations, it resonates far beyond the court.



Q: This year's Creative Economy Journal focuses on the intersection of sports and creativity. Could you share how your WNBA partnership reflects Delta's broader strategy of connecting with communities through sports?

Tillman: Our partnership with the WNBA reflects Delta's deep commitment to equity in women's sports and our broader strategy of connecting with communities through meaningful storytelling. We're proud to be the official airline of the WNBA. Through initiatives like our Power Forward series, we're able to spotlight athletes who are redefining leadership and opening doors for future generations. These stories resonate because they're authentic and reflect the values our customers care about. Whether in the skies or on the court, Delta is committed to elevating the experience and visibility of women in sports.

Q: How do you measure the impact of these creative investments—whether through customer engagement, brand loyalty or other metrics?

Tillman: We measure impact by how deeply our stories resonate with our customers and drive meaningful engagement. With initiatives like our WNBA partnership and the Power Forward series, we look beyond impressions and views. We focus on emotional connection, brand affinity and community response. When our creative investments lead to stronger relationships and lasting loyalty, that's when we know we've made a real impact.

Q: If you could leave readers with one takeaway about Delta's philosophy on creativity and brand connection, what would it be?

Tillman: At Delta, creativity is how we build meaningful relationships with our customers. We don't just aim to be an airline; we strive to be a brand that reflects the lifestyles, values and aspirations of the people we serve. Whether it's through our partnerships with platforms like YouTube, our storytelling in series like Power Forward or the design of our on board and event experiences, every touchpoint is crafted to feel personal, relevant and inspiring. Creativity is how we show care, spark connection and stay culturally relevant—and that's what makes our brand truly resonate.

WNBA PLAYERS
CAMERON BRINK,
NNEKA OGWUMIKE,
& BREANNA STEWART



“We’re proud to be the official airline of the WNBA.”

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ART & ATHLETICS

A HIGHER PLAYING FIELD IN GEORGIA

Peter Relic

Staff Writer

National champions deserve championship-level facilities and resources, and Georgia continues to deliver.

For more than 45 years, Savannah College of Art and Design has helped define Georgia's creative landscape, preparing superstars of the stage and screen while expanding its reach into sports and competition. That creative spirit now extends to a new arena: athletics, where artist-athletes are making national headlines and driving investment in state-of-the-art facilities.

The latest milestone is the new SCAD Athletic Complex, a transformative development that will serve the university's lacrosse and soccer programs and further position Savannah as a destination where art, innovation and athletics thrive side by side. The new complex will bring state-of-the-art locker rooms and an athletic training space to the university's existing sports fields north of Savannah, helping artist-athletes continue competing at the highest level, elevating SCAD athletics programs and contributing to the overall growth and success of the university.

"Our soccer and lacrosse teams have a wonderful history of excellence, our alumni have paved the way to the success we see today, and I couldn't be more thrilled to enhance the experience of our teams while adding to the future of each program with this athletic complex expansion," said SCAD Savannah Director of Athletics Amanda Haverstick.

The new facilities will magnify the university's ability to host conference and national tournaments, showcasing the prowess of SCAD athletics teams and bringing national attention to SCAD and the Savannah region. In addition to enhancing teams' competitive edge, these improvements will significantly raise recruitment efforts. The facility will serve as a beacon for prospective student-athletes, illustrating SCAD's commitment to providing the highest-quality resources for their athletic and academic pursuits.

"The SCAD athletics fields have become a special place filled with memories of the teams that play and work hard there, and it deserves to be expanded to match the work the artist-athletes put into competition while maintaining their placement in the classroom," said women's lacrosse standout alumna Grace Gibson (B.F.A., business of beauty and fragrance, 2024). "SCAD offers something no other art school does; it's the place where my athletics and creative careers grew in tandem, and that is so special."

The SCAD lacrosse and soccer teams are among the most decorated at the school, earning consistent top-20 rankings and winning conference and NAIA national titles. The women's lacrosse team is one of the most successful in the NAIA, with frequent top-five rankings and six national championships in its history.

The women's soccer team won the Sun Conference regular season and tournament titles for the first time in program history in 2023 and went on to win the NAIA national championship in 2024. It was the first 20-win season in program history for SCAD women's soccer. The Bees finished the season with a 20-1-2 overall record and brought the NAIA national championship trophy home after a 4-1 victory over Keiser University on Dec. 9, 2024.

"The new SCAD Athletics Complex will provide a championship environment to match the championship mindset we instill in our artist-athletes every day," said women's soccer head coach Rebecca Gunn. "Having a facility to call home encourages our family culture, one that builds the commitment, competitiveness and relationships that lead to success on and off the field. The on-site facility will lead to extra time to focus on tactical breakdowns and aid in pregame treatment and postgame recovery, adding to the artist-athlete experience and putting us on par with other universities of our caliber."

In addition to these team accolades, artist-athletes frequently receive conference and national honors. Multiple NAIA All-Americans and NAIA Daktronics Scholar-Athlete honors reflect success on the playing field and in the classroom. These accomplishments underscore the school's dedication to excellence in both academics and athletics, demonstrating the caliber of talent and commitment within the SCAD community.

Each year, SCAD hosts about 50 home games for its lacrosse and soccer teams. Including players and fans for both teams, these events can bring in at least 200 people per game, or more than 10,000 visitors each academic year. SCAD teams are at the athletic fields five to six days per week based on practice and game schedules; four daily practices totaling eight hours a day are common when team schedules overlap. The complex will be used consistently throughout the year, and its expanded facilities will offer opportunities to host more events, including regional and national tournaments and exclusive exhibitions.



...there has never been a better time to invest in its future and provide our student-athletes with the opportunity to be part of this global movement."



**FIRST UP, FIRST DOWN:
FLAG FOOTBALL
ARRIVES AT SCAD**

Before flag football comes to the Olympics, the sport is arriving in Savannah. SCAD has added women's flag football to its lineup of varsity sports, with the first competition slated for spring 2027.

"SCAD is committed to supporting artist-athletes through intentional program growth and investment, and I am thrilled to announce the addition of women's flag football to SCAD Athletics," said Haverstick. "This is an incredibly exciting step forward for SCAD, reflecting our commitment to expanding opportunities, fostering inclusivity and supporting the growing enthusiasm for this fast-paced, competitive sport. With flag football set to debut in the 2028 Olympics, there has never been a better time to invest in its future and provide our student-athletes with the opportunity to be part of this global movement."

As one of the fastest-growing sports in the United States, the International Federation of American Football states that 2.4 million children under age 17 are participating in organized flag football in the U.S. Seventeen states have officially sanctioned girls' flag football as a high school varsity sport, including Georgia, Florida, Tennessee and Alabama. An

additional 17 states are conducting pilot test seasons.

The NAIA's National Administrative Council Executive Committee has approved women's flag football as an invitational sport for the 2025-26 season. Women's flag football launched as an emerging sport in the NAIA in 2021. The upcoming season will feature 35 programs competing in the NAIA, and beginning in the spring, the postseason will shift to a qualification-based invitational tournament.

SCAD Bees will join Brewton-Parker, Florida Memorial, Keiser, Life, Point, Reinhardt, St. Thomas, Thomas, Warner and Webber International in the Sun Conference. SCAD has initiated a nationwide search for its first head coach and aims to field its inaugural team for competition in spring 2027.

SCAD's expansion of its athletic programs reflects a larger movement across Georgia where sports, creativity and economic development intersect. From film studios and gaming labs to arenas and athletic fields, Georgia's creative economy is increasingly defined by collaboration between culture and competition.

As institutions like SCAD continue to invest in world-class facilities and experiences, they help shape a future where the arts and athletics share the same stage, each inspiring the other to reach new heights.

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DESIGNING THE FUTURE

HOW GEORGIA'S SNEAKER
SCENE IS SHAPING A NEW
CREATIVE ECONOMY

Miliana Palacios-Ruiz

Staff Writer

Inside SCAD Atlanta's Industrial Design and Game Development building, creativity runs from sketchpad to sneaker sole. Students hunch over benches, sketching designs that will transform into 3D models by sunrise, while printers hum and prototypes cool on steel racks. This is more than a classroom; it's a glimpse into Georgia's next creative boom. Through the nation's first accredited sneaker design degree, SCAD is helping position the South as a hub where design, engineering and entrepreneurship meet, redefining how fashion and technology move from idea to marketplace.

Between being a fashion statement and a status symbol, sneakers have outgrown their box. Quintin Williams, a SCAD alumnus, professor and founder of Q4 Sports, traces today's frenzy to resale platforms that turned limited-edition shoes into tradable assets. "The stock market in shoes," he says, nodding to StockX and GOAT, "changed the whole landscape." SCAD tracked that culture, first piloting a sneaker design minor in 2022, then building graduate degrees devoted to the field.



Illustration by
Jamie Boddie



Images by
Alexa Carmona



The coursework mirrors how modern shoes are actually made, drawing on principles from industrial design, graphic design and fashion. Students transition from sketching and technical design to digital prototyping, using tools like Vizcom, an AI-powered conceptualization platform that turns hand sketches into photorealistic renders. Those files are then converted into VR, where their forms are refined and sent to the 3D print lab.

"AI, 3D printing, that's the future," Williams says. "We're already doing it; the masses just haven't caught on to it yet." Williams explains how 3D printing needs to scale down so people can adapt to this new way of sustainable footwear. And slowly, it's trickling down the funnel. Within months of each other, Nike and Adidas released 3D printed collections at real commercial scale. It's the next phase of evolution, built on end-to-end fluidity.

But Williams clarifies, "There's always going to be a space for handmade, artisan products." With the sudden rise of AI, 3D printing may heighten public concerns. However, Williams points out that humans have only ever chased evolution. From rotary to cell phones, technology is rooted in efficiency. With that in mind, Williams asks us to consider, "Did you lose anything, or did you just gain more efficiency of the same thing that you were after, which was knowledge?"

Luckily, Atlanta is the right testing ground. The city's passion for music, sports and streetwear demands innovation. Local creatives, like Eastside Golf, have created their own boom, attracting brand collaborations from giant footwear companies such as Nike. For decades, U.S. footwear manufacturing moved overseas. Now, additive manufacturing can bring parts of the process back, shifting production to printing.

That shift favors Georgia. The state has footwear production familiarity with Okabashi's Buford factory, which is one of the few U.S. shoemakers still producing at scale. Pair that base with SCAD's VR-to-print skill set, and you have the bones of a Southern manufacturing network. Unlike traditional industry demands for large minimums for footwear with lengthy shipping chains, 3D printing collapses the process into lower upfront costs and smaller quantities to print. There even lies the possibility for scan-to-fit sizing, which SCAD is already exploring, according to Williams.

As technology matures, personalization is realized. Back in the lab, the prototypes on the rack point to a new footwear economy designed for the people. With sneakers being "more cultural than ever," as Williams points out, it's critical to center design on users. These products already carry identity, culture and business. Now it's time to localize production and personalize fit, because, at the end of the day, shoes should fit lives and not just sizes.

What's happening in SCAD's sneaker labs represents more than the evolution of footwear; it's a signal of where Georgia's creative economy is heading. By blending artistry, sustainability and advanced manufacturing, students and entrepreneurs are building the foundation for a new kind of industry, one that values culture and community as much as innovation. In a state known for storytelling through film, music and design, sneakers may just become the next chapter in Georgia's creative revolution.



LIVE THEATER TACKLES THE FOURTH WALL

Carol Badaracco Padgett

Senior Staff Writer

The worlds of live sports and media entertainment are fused so tightly that it's difficult to distinguish a crack in the curtain. And now, in a convergence some audiences didn't see coming, live musical theater has shot onto our screens like a pole vault or a pirouette.

It has made us sing "Defying Gravity" in a cinema packed with strangers who became our friend group for the runtime. We're together. We're fans. And it doesn't matter if we don't know all the words.

Today, theater is speaking straight to its audience through screens, both mobile and fixed.

ADRENALINE DANCES WITH ART

Georgia has been busting through the fourth wall, the imaginary barrier between actor and audience, for nearly a quarter of a century by hosting a powerhouse event that draws New York's top talents south each year: the Junior Theater Festival, born in 2002.

Held annually at the 144,000-square-foot Cobb Galleria Centre, northwest of downtown Atlanta, the three-day JTF event fills the venue to capacity with young musical theater performers, including the rising stars of Broadway and the globe, along with their families and school teachers.

JTF is also held on the West Coast in Sacramento, California, and in Europe, Australia and New Zealand. It is reportedly the world's largest gathering and celebration of young people who perform musical theater.

According to JTF Worldwide founder and CEO Timothy Allen McDonald, a musical theater director, producer, librettist and author based in New York, the stage-to-screen educational

event he founded has served up-and-coming performers and cultivated an audience that might otherwise have never existed.

"For live theater, in particular, less than one percent of humans get to see a Broadway show," McDonald says. "I create Broadway Junior shows that have a North American audience of 36 million. With that, we're still only scratching 20 percent of the potential global viewers. So if you think about how you provide that access, you have to film it and broadcast it."

In addition to the 2024 blockbuster theater-to-film adaptation of "Wicked" starring Ariana Grande and Cynthia Erivo, which snagged 10 Academy Award nominations in 2025, McDonald points to the earlier success of the Broadway musical "Hamilton," which was live-streamed on Disney+ in July 2020 after a planned 2021 theatrical release fell through due to the coronavirus pandemic.

As Disney's streaming and broadcast involvement in JTF shows, investment in youth theater signals the reach of the theater-to-film movement. Amazon sees the wisdom, too, and is collaborating with McDonald on distribution.

Aside from the business moves, what do students, tomorrow's theater and film artists, gain? World-class education and a stage on which to break through. For each annual three-day event in Atlanta, JTF draws global student troupes who each perform a 15-minute show from a Broadway musical before a panel of judges made up of experts from around the world. The weekend includes workshops for students, teachers and parents and a grand finale concert headlined by Broadway's best in the Galleria's 25,000-square-foot ballroom. Event sponsors include Playbill, Music Theatre International and Disney Musicals.



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It's an opportunity students relish, and it's a symbiotic relationship that also benefits the business side. At JTF in January 2025, more than 8,000 performers, creators, crew, supporters and enthusiasts attended, making metro Atlanta their home base for three to four days.

From the student-family-instructor attendees to the film and television crew members, manufacturer teams, contractors, electricians, visual artists and others who ate, drank and slept all things JTF preparation for weeks leading up to the event, then lingered long after for strike down, the Atlanta economy received an estimated \$3.4 million boost.

That impact underscores how youth theater contributes to culture and to Georgia's tourism and economic development, priorities state leaders are working to strengthen through policy.

Recognizing the potential of bringing live theater to the screen, Disney has served as a broadcast partner since 2005, supporting and capitalizing on JTF by producing and distributing coverage to viewers worldwide.

Of note, 2025 marked the first year JTF and Disney captured a world premiere Disney musical live on stage, then distributed it across Disney's platforms, including Disney+, YouTube and Amazon Prime. Hosting JTF in Atlanta means Georgia itself becomes the launchpad for global creative distribution. The city also houses the newest phase of Junior Theater Festival Productions LLC, which is now a Georgia corporation, with its offices and stage sets warehoused in the ICP Production Centre on Boat Rock Boulevard, anchoring the event's production right in the metro area.

WHAT SPORTS TAUGHT THE THEATER PRO

Even in the instance of JTF, sports converge with entertainment. Back when McDonald was learning the ropes of theater management in his first jobs in New York, he wanted to find a way to attract young people to theater and prepare them for professional careers. So he founded Broadway Junior, an organization devoted to helping young enthusiasts and schools produce and perform Broadway musicals adapted for

young performers and their audiences.

"I had this concept, and I wanted to understand how Little League baseball and football became such strong programs in schools, why they're in schools, and what the history was," McDonald says.

What he learned was this: sports' infiltration of schools was a purposeful way of cultivating and preparing top young talent to become professional athletes. "You have to teach kids how to start, and competition is good for that," McDonald says. "Competition means the field for what you're doing gets stronger. So I studied the Little League World Series concept and how it started, and I thought, what if we applied that to theater?"

In his work with Broadway Junior and during the early stages of JTF, McDonald applied the baseball and football training model to educational theater programs. "I pitched this competition for youth in theater idea to regional theaters, six different ones, and they all thought I was crazy except for Theater of the Stars," McDonald says. That Georgia nonprofit company, once run by producer Christopher B. Manos, ran for 60 seasons. "And he said, I'm in. Let's do it."

In 2003, the first JTF took place at the Fox Theatre in Atlanta. Two years later, McDonald met with Tom Schumacher at Disney Theatrical with an idea. "You've got all these titles, all these IPs, just sitting on the shelves," he told Schumacher. "Let me turn them into musicals for schools." Schumacher said yes. "So in 2005, we introduced the world to the Disney collection. We started with Aladdin, and that was the magic key," McDonald says.

By 2007, JTF had grown so popular with student troupes from around the world that the event moved to the Cobb Galleria Centre.

INSTANT REPLAY

Today, the JTF event is broadcast live globally, far exceeding the 8,000 theater students, families and teachers who travel to Atlanta each year. "There is an entire world, a universe, that wants to be part of this," McDonald says. "And so we live capture everything, and it's broadcast all weekend long as a reality show, essentially. The show is a production set

for a worldwide broadcast."

In addition to drawing in attendees and viewers from around the globe, JTF at the Galleria in 2025 employed more than 500 Georgia residents, including film and television crew members, contractors, electricians, manufacturer teams and visual artists.

In keeping with the importance of all these roles, JTF also offers an in-depth theater tech track. The event highlights how Georgia's workforce, infrastructure and incentive environment serve not just film and television but also live theater and convergent entertainment.

In the end, it all comes back to the student, whether of theater, television, entertainment, technology, marketing or



business. And to their futures, where all fields are equally impacted in a convergence of media, community and possibility.

McDonald puts it in perspective: "These young people who attend JTF are going into the arts. They're going into film and television, and for those who don't, they are still going to have the skill set of understanding how to communicate, how to collaborate, and how to create something with other people. Something greater than what you could ever create by yourself."

All photos courtesy of Junior Theater Festival



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